

AP Human Geography: The Complete Exam Guide

All 7 units explained, the models and theories you must know, the three free-response question types, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**2:15**

hours total
60 + 75 minutes

60+3

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

7 units

population to
development

65–66%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) combines a multiple-choice section and a free-response section, each worth half. Many questions are built around maps, data and images.

50%

Section I · Multiple choice · 60 questions

50%

Section II · Free response · 3 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I · Multiple choice	50% of score 1 hour 60 questions	Analyze geographic concepts, data from maps, charts and graphs, and spatial relationships at different scales.
II · Free response	50% of score 1 hr 15 min 3 questions	Q1 has no stimulus (text only) · Q2 uses one stimulus (data, image or map) · Q3 uses two stimuli. Each question has several parts (A–G).

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

THINK SPATIALLY

Scale and patterns matter

Human Geography asks **where** things are and **why there**. Practice explaining patterns at local, regional, national and global scales.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

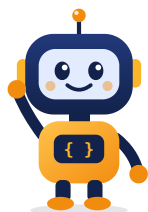
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 12 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Learn every model with its **limitations**. Free-response questions often ask where a model fails to explain the real world.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

60 questions in 60 minutes, exactly one minute each. Maps and charts take longer, so answer vocabulary questions quickly.

60

questions, many with maps or data

1:00

minute per question on average

50%

of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong answer, so never leave one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

Units 2–7

Each content unit

12–17%

Unit 1

Thinking Geographically

8–10%

0%

10%

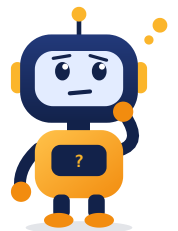
20%

What this means for your study time: Units 2–7 each carry about the same weight, so balance your review. Unit 1's map skills and scale ideas appear inside every other unit too.

Strategies that work on this section

- Read the map title, legend and scale before the question.
- Match the model to the clue: stages and birth rates mean the demographic transition; zones and rings mean urban models.
- Know your vocabulary precisely: relocation vs expansion diffusion; push vs pull factors.
- Think about scale: an answer can be true globally but false locally.
- Eliminate extreme words like "always" and "only".
- Move on at one minute and come back to flagged maps.

One minute per question! **Vocabulary questions** should take 20 seconds so maps get more time.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 7 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these seven units.

UNIT 1 8–10%	Thinking Geographically Be ready to: read maps and projections; use GIS, GPS and data; explain scale, region, distance decay and human-environment interaction.	UNIT 2 12–17%	Population & Migration Be ready to: use population pyramids, density and the demographic transition model; explain Malthus; push-pull factors and types of migration.
UNIT 3 12–17%	Cultural Patterns & Processes Be ready to: explain cultural landscapes; types of diffusion; the spread of languages and religions; globalization and acculturation.	UNIT 4 12–17%	Political Patterns & Processes Be ready to: distinguish state, nation and nation-state; boundary types; federal and unitary states; devolution and supranationalism.
UNIT 5 12–17%	Agriculture & Rural Land Use Be ready to: explain the agricultural revolutions; von Thünen's model; commercial and subsistence farming; the Green Revolution; food systems and sustainability.	UNIT 6 12–17%	Cities & Urban Land Use Be ready to: apply urban models (Burgess, Hoyt, Harris-Ullman, Latin American, African, Southeast Asian); central place theory; rank-size rule; urban challenges and sustainability.
UNIT 7 12–17%	Industrial & Economic Development Be ready to: explain the Industrial Revolution's spread; economic sectors; measures of development (GDP, HDI, GII); Rostow and Wallerstein; Weber's location theory.		

◆ Models you must know, with one limitation each

Model	What it explains	A key limitation
Demographic transition	How birth and death rates change as countries develop	Based on European history; may not fit all countries
Von Thünen	Where farming types locate around a market	Assumes flat, uniform land and one market
Burgess concentric zone	Rings of land use around a city center	Based on Chicago; ignores transport corridors
Rostow's stages	Five stages of economic growth	Assumes all countries follow one path
Wallerstein world-systems	Core, semi-periphery and periphery	Can underplay local factors and change
Weber's least cost	Where factories locate to minimize costs	Assumes perfect competition; ignores subsidies

SECTION II

04

The 3 free-response questions

75 minutes, 3 questions of 7 parts each. The stimulus pattern is the same every year: none, one, then two.

Q1 · no stimulus

Q2 · one stimulus

Q3 · two stimuli

Each question is worth the same: 7 points

Q1

Text only

~25 minutes

A scenario or concept with no map or chart. You define, describe, explain and apply concepts from memory.

Use precise vocabulary and a real-world example for each part.

Q2

One stimulus

~25 minutes

A map, chart, image or table to interpret, then connect to concepts and explain patterns.

Quote specific data from the stimulus in your answer.

Q3

Two stimuli

~25 minutes

Two sources to compare and connect, often at different scales or time periods.

Refer to both stimuli, and say which one you are using.

♦ A time plan for the 75 minutes

Q1

~25 min

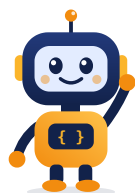
Q2

~25 min

Q3

~25 min

A suggested split, not a rule. Start with the question type you're strongest at, and never leave a question blank.



Each part has a **task verb**: identify, describe, explain, compare. Do exactly what it asks.

05 FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a full-credit answer

Here is a practice question part with a full-credit answer, and the habits that earn points.

PRACTICE TASK · WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (Q2 style): A population pyramid shows a country with a wide base, a sharply narrowing top, and a total fertility rate of 4.8. (a) Identify the stage of the demographic transition model. (b) Explain one economic reason for the high fertility rate. (c) Explain one limitation of using the demographic transition model to predict this country's future.

Full-credit response

- ① (a) Stage 2 (early expanding).
- ② (b) In largely agricultural economies, children work on family farms and support parents in old age, so families have an economic incentive to have more children.
- ③ (c) The model is based on the experience of Western Europe, where industrialization drove the transition.
- ④ This country may not industrialize the same way, and factors such as government policy, religion or the status of women may change fertility differently, so it may not follow the same stages or timing.

- ① **Identify** needs only a short, accurate answer.
- ② **Explain** needs a cause and its effect.
- ③ **State the limitation** of the model clearly.
- ④ **Apply it** to this country with a specific reason.

◆ Five habits for every free-response question

- 1**
Match the task verb in each part exactly.
- 2**
Use precise vocabulary from the course.
- 3**
Give a real place as an example when asked.
- 4**
Refer to the stimulus by name in Q2 and Q3.
- 5**
Stuck? Define the key term; it can still earn a point.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

A nation and a state are the **same thing!** (Nope.)



01 Nation vs state

A state is a political unit with sovereignty; a nation is a group with a shared culture. A nation-state is where they match.

02 Types of diffusion

Relocation diffusion spreads by people moving; expansion diffusion (hierarchical, contagious, stimulus) spreads while staying in place.

03 Arithmetic vs physiological density

Physiological density is people per unit of **arable** land, so it reveals pressure on farmland.

04 Push vs pull

Push factors make people leave; pull factors attract them to a destination.

05 Wrong urban model

Burgess has rings, Hoyt has sectors, Harris-Ullman has multiple nuclei. Know which is which.

06 Ignoring scale

A pattern at one scale may disappear at another. Name the scale you are discussing.

07 Development measures

GDP measures output; HDI adds education and life expectancy; GII measures gender inequality.

08 Model without limits

For any model, be ready to give one assumption it makes that the real world breaks.

09 Vague examples

"Some countries" scores less than naming a specific country or city.

10 Describing instead of explaining

"Explain" needs a reason why; describing what happens is not enough.

Quick self-check: can you name one example each of relocation, hierarchical and contagious diffusion? If not, review Unit 3.

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and review maps and models every week.



Sep – Oct

Foundations



Units 1–2

Maps, scale, population and migration. Learn the demographic transition model with examples.

Nov – Dec

Culture + politics



Units 3–4

Diffusion, language, religion, boundaries and devolution. Start one free-response question per week.

Jan – Feb

Agriculture



Unit 5

Agricultural revolutions, von Thünen and food systems. Practice model limitations.

Mar – Apr

Cities + development



Units 6–7

Urban models and economic development. Begin timed 60-question sets.

Early May

Sharpen



Full timed sections

All three free-response types under timing. Review the models table and traps list.

Exam day

May



AP Human Geography exam

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

● **The final four weeks**

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 30 multiple-choice questions plus one free-response question	List your two weakest units
3 weeks out	Drill models and their limitations	One limitation per model
2 weeks out	Full 2-hour-15-minute practice exam	Finish both sections on time
Final week	Light review: vocabulary, models, traps list	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **12 minutes** for all ten, then check page 10.

1 UNIT 2 · DENSITY

Country A has a high arithmetic density but a much higher physiological density. What does this suggest?

- A It has little arable land relative to its population
- B Most of its land is suitable for farming
- C Its population is declining
- D It has a very low birth rate

2 UNIT 2 · DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

A country has a low death rate, a rapidly falling birth rate and fast urbanization. Which stage is it most likely in?

- A Stage 1
- B Stage 2
- C Stage 3
- D Stage 5

3 UNIT 3 · DIFFUSION

A new fashion trend starts in major global cities and then spreads to smaller cities and towns. This is an example of:

- A relocation diffusion
- B contagious diffusion
- C stimulus diffusion
- D hierarchical diffusion

4 UNIT 4 · BOUNDARIES

A boundary drawn along a line of latitude, without regard to physical or cultural features, is:

- A a geometric boundary
- B an antecedent boundary
- C a relic boundary
- D a consequent boundary

5 UNIT 4 · DEVOLUTION

Which is the best example of devolution?

- A Several countries forming a free-trade agreement
- B A country annexing a neighboring territory
- C A city expanding its suburbs
- D A central government transferring powers to a regional parliament such as Scotland's

6 UNIT 5 · VON THÜNEN

In von Thünen's model, which activity is located closest to the market?

- A Ranching
- B Grain farming
- C Dairy and market gardening
- D Forestry for firewood

7 UNIT 6 · URBAN MODELS

Which urban model shows high-income housing extending outward from the city center along a transportation corridor?

- A Concentric zone model
- B Sector model
- C Multiple nuclei model
- D Galactic city model

8 UNIT 6 · RANK-SIZE RULE

Under the rank-size rule, if a country's largest city has 6 million people, about how many live in its third-largest city?

- A 1 million
- B 2 million
- C 3 million
- D 4 million

9 UNIT 7 · DEVELOPMENT

Which measure would best show differences in well-being between men and women in a country?

- A GDP per capita
- B Gross National Income
- C Arithmetic density
- D Gender Inequality Index

10 UNIT 7 · WORLD-SYSTEMS

In Wallerstein's world-systems theory, a country that exports mainly raw materials and has low wages is most likely part of the:

- A periphery
- B core
- C semi-periphery
- D central business district

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	A	Physiological density divides population by arable land. Much higher physiological density means little farmland per person.
2	C · Stage 3	Stage 3 has low death rates and falling birth rates, often alongside urbanization and industrialization.
3	D	Hierarchical diffusion spreads from places of higher status or size to lower ones, skipping places in between.
4	A	Geometric boundaries follow straight lines such as latitude, like much of the U.S.–Canada border.
5	D	Devolution transfers power from the central government to regions, such as the Scottish Parliament in the UK.
6	C	Perishable, high-value products such as dairy and vegetables are produced closest to the market to reduce spoilage and transport time.
7	B	Hoyt's sector model shows wedges, with high-income housing following a transport corridor outward.
8	B · 2 million	Rank-size: the nth city has 1/n the population of the largest. $6 \text{ million} \div 3 = 2 \text{ million}$.
9	D	The Gender Inequality Index measures differences in health, empowerment and labor market participation between women and men.
10	A	Periphery countries export raw materials, have low wages and depend on core countries for manufactured goods and investment.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Learn the key models and vocabulary for each unit first.

10 KNOW THE TARGET How students score

In recent years, about 65–66% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Human Geography, and about 17–19% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

65–66%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

17–19%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: **1 min** per multiple-choice question and **25 min** per free-response question
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review every **model and one limitation** of each
- ☐ Practice reading maps quickly: title, legend, scale

In the free-response section: match each task verb, use precise vocabulary, refer to the stimulus by name, and support explanations with real places as examples.



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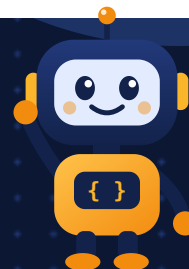
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Concept tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all seven units, with map and model drills.

Free-response coaching

Practice all three question types and get feedback against rubric-style criteria.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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